STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 10 · The Father Who Does Not Leave

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey. Good to see you. Uh, a few of you found your spot from last time without even looking up. That's alright. You came back. A couple of you promised somebody this would be quick. Quick does not come with a workbook this thick. You came in anyway. I'll take that. Last time you named, uh, the way you leave when the weight gets real. Anger. The itch. The drift. Some of you said the true word. Some of you, uh, got most of the way there. You told the truth about the exit. You know, an exit can get a man out of a room. It cannot father him. The ache needs a Father. If you're new with us, I'm Wes. Glad you sat down. Now listen. Uh, the word father does something in a room like this. For some of you, you know, it sits easy. For some of you it, uh, catches. I know that catch. We will not, uh, make a joke out of it. And we will not spend this hour building another list of what was missing. You've already, uh, told the truth about the man. Some of you are tired of the list. That tiredness makes sense. Uh, you can be the strong one for years. Run the day. Pay what's due. Keep everybody steady. And still be listening for a man to finish one sentence. I mean, I know that listen. It dresses up as faith. You call it patience. Under the nicer word, there's a boy at the window. He has been there a long time. Today we walk him to a Father who is already in the room. We will— we will go slow. Uh, if the word scrapes on the way out, you are in the right room. Receiving is the door. You don't have to feel ready first. We'll stay with you while you learn to say it. Today is who is here. A Father who does not leave.

One sentence holds four marks of a real man. You've heard them, uh, in this room. I'll say them again. I won't pull them apart today. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. That last line only holds if the God you picture is the real one. A man will not rest his life on a father he thinks might walk off. So today the marks can sit in your mouth. The question under them is simpler. Who have you been living them in front of? Here's the thing. You have been reading God through your dad. You know, every man does it. His was the first picture of a father you had, so you held it up and figured heaven matched. I have— I have done that for years. Scripture turns the picture around. God is the Father. The man you learned the word from was never the definition. You learn the man by looking at Jesus. You don't learn Jesus by staring at the man until he turns into God. He will— he will not. Uh, give him more years. He is still a man. If you can still call yours, call him. Honor him. That call is love. That call is a different page than this one. You know, a lot of men will give God the work and the worry and keep one room inside for a human who might still come through. Uh, that room stays hungry. I've— I've fed it by being the capable one. I've fed it by being needed. Neither one ever said the sentence. A paycheck can clap you on the back. A full house can need you. The sentence you're hungry for does not live in either place. This page is the Father who stays.

Let me name the pictures without making you live in them all afternoon. Uh, some of you had a father who was a rumor. You could talk about him. You could not reach him. So God feels like a number you were given and never told how to dial. You pray, and you don't expect a ring. Uh, some of you had a man in the house. He was two feet away and the only words were about the work. Hand me that. Move that. We're done. You learned, uh, that near can still be mute. Your prayers go out like work orders and come back with no voice on them. Some of you, uh, learned the house by the way the front door shut. You knew the night before anybody spoke. You still pray like a man listening for which God walked in. You're fairly sure the mad one came for you. And some of you, I mean, had a good man. I did. He showed up. He paid what needed paying. There was still a sentence that never quite got said. So you thank God easily, and you leave the need out, because needing sounds ungrateful. You held one of those pictures up to heaven. Maybe more than one. It has been doing your praying for you. Right? You didn't frame it and hang it on purpose. You just, uh, grew up inside it and carried it into every prayer. A rumor teaches you not to expect much. A mute house teaches you to keep it short. A hard door teaches you to come in small. A good man with a missing sentence teaches you to be grateful and still alone. Name yours before we leave this part. Uh, hold it loose. We'll need the plain name later. How many of you can already name yours? Just a hand. The story can wait. Yeah. Keep the name of it. We'll use it at the tables.

Uh, I want to tell on myself before I say another word about your picture. My boy asked me what my dad was like. I hurried. He was a good man. We're good. Some of you heard me own that speed. Here is the part under it. I got, uh, very good at thanks. I am slow at need. A decent dad can teach you that without ever meaning to. You don't want to sound like a complaint against a man who tried. So you pray, you know, the highlights. The health. The work. The day going fine. And you carry the heavy part yourself and call it respect. It isn't respect. It's a son who never practiced being carried. Uh, I can say Lord all afternoon. I can say God. Uh, Father is the word that sticks. Father means somebody close enough to hand the weight to. I wasn't sure I was allowed. You can— you can believe every true sentence about God and still pray like a man who plans to handle it. That was me. A lot of mornings, uh, it still is. So the move today is small and hard. Set the picture down. Some of you are still hoping the next visit is the one. He'll be softer. Uh, he'll finally see you. I hope you get a kind hour with him. Take the hour. Love him in it. Just don't make him God while you're waiting on the hour. Say it in your chest if you have to. You know, the hope is tender. I have lived in that hope. It gets heavy when a man has to be God too. I have been asking a man to do God's job. Stop running the test where a human man finally becomes God if you wait him out, or impress him, or need less. He will stay the size he is. The place you've been asking him to fill was made for your Father.

John fourteen, verse nine. Anyone who has seen me has seen the Father. How can you say, Show us the Father? Whatever Jesus is like, the Father is like. Not whatever your dad was like. Whatever Jesus is like. That is the correction. Stay with one thing, uh, He shows. The Father

comes toward you. You know the friend who texts that he's in the driveway while you're still editing the message that asks him to come. You hadn't decided you were allowed to need him. He was— he was already there. You don't have to show up cleaned up. You don't have to have the speech ready. Uh, I've rewritten prayers in the truck until I sounded like a man who had recovered. Then I called the wait respect. He wants the man you actually are on the day you actually have. That is the shape. I do the opposite, and it's small, and it tells on me. Uh, I was in a hardware aisle with a bolt I couldn't name. The man in the vest was right there. I nodded like I knew the size. I did not know. I paid. I went home. The bolt fit nothing I own. Uh, I still didn't go back. Asking felt louder than being wrong. That is a silly story until you hear it in your prayers. You tidy, uh, the sentence. You wait until you sound like a man who has it mostly together. You call the tidying reverence. A lot of the time it's fear. Bring— bring Him the unfinished man. Uh, the bolt was a small confession. The prayers were the bigger one. A son gets to come in unfinished. The Father is not standing back until your speech is good enough. He comes toward a son who is still a mess in the mouth.

Matthew three, verse seventeen. And a voice from heaven said, This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased. Uh, hear where it sits. Before the sermons. Before a healing. Before anybody in the towns had a reason to clap. The Father said the sentence first. My Son. That is belonging. Whom I love. That is His heart toward him. With him I am well pleased. That is delight, and it landed before the resume. Uh, most of us got the order backwards, if we got the words at all. Do enough. Then maybe you'll hear it. The Father reversed that order on the day His Son stepped into the water. Blessing first. The work after. If you have been performing for a voice you only hear after a win, hear the order one more time. The name came first. You know, the work was handed out after. You can stop trying to earn your own name. Your own father may have made you earn words that were supposed to be a gift. This Father gives them. If needing that voice feels like weakness, stay with the Son. The beloved Son heard it anyway. You are not more mature than He is for going without. I have tried, uh, to earn breakfast. List first. Food if the list behaved. Nobody was grading the eggs. I was, though. In my head, uh, every morning. A son eats because he is a son. The shift comes after the name. If you are in Christ, that sentence is already over you. You don't assemble it by a better month. If you're not sure you're in Christ, don't dress it up. Tell Him you're not sure. He is not hiding from a man who will say the plain thing. Mine. Loved. Well pleased. Before the proof.

He carries you. He knows the need before you get a word on it. Your needing does not make Him lean away. I watched a brother once, you know, get an arm under a sick friend outside a clinic and just walk him to the door. No speech. No tally at the end. Uh, the sick one kept apologizing. The other one kept walking. That is nearer your Father than the scorekeeping a lot of us pray with. Stay with that picture if you grew up apologizing for taking up space. Uh, let the apologizing rest. He is— he is walking you in. Your Father is not keeping score on the walk. If needing was, uh, dangerous in your house, don't rush past that. I mean, sit in it a minute. The

Father you have is not tired of the weight. He stays. John fourteen, verse eighteen. I will not leave you as orphans; I will come to you. He used that word because those men were about to feel it. Some of you have felt it, uh, since you were a boy. Hear the other half. I will come to you. Hebrews thirteen, verse five. Never will I leave you; never will I forsake you. And if the season is hard, you know, hear this before you decide He left. Hebrews twelve, verse seven. Endure hardship as discipline; God is treating you as his sons. Discipline and rage were never the same thing. A hard stretch can mean He stayed. The man who learned to flinch needs that said slow. Rage throws you out. A Father's correction keeps you in the house. He is not a trick for feeling better before supper. He stays in the hurt with you. The hurt gets a hearing. It does not get the throne. You can tell Him what the man did. You can tell Him what you did. You still belong to Him.

Let me tell you about a man I sat with. Uh, I'll call him Calvin. He worked on diesel trucks. He was the man you called. He had a rule he never wrote down. Don't be the one who needs. His old man was in the house and hard to bother. Calvin learned to solve a thing before anybody had to wake up to it. It looked like strength. It was a boy keeping the peace by needing nothing. One afternoon a starter was half out of a truck. Uh, Calvin's back locked. His legs, uh, quit the argument. A younger guy on the crew didn't make a speech. He got an arm under Calvin's chest and took the weight. Calvin told me later he came an inch from shoving him off. The pain wasn't the reason. Being the one held felt like losing in front of his own men. He had stood alone so long that help felt like an insult. He didn't go in the house right away. Uh, sat in the driveway with the engine off. Tried to pray the usual list. Jobs. Money. His boy's grades. The list ran out and the back was still wrong. He said the word he had been avoiding. Father. Then one sentence. I can't get myself to the door. He told me it felt foolish, like he'd picked up a word from a house he didn't live in. He kept at it, uh, on the drive to work. Father. One plain sentence about the day. After a string of those mornings, his boy had a truck that wouldn't turn over. Calvin's whole body, uh, went for the wrench. He stopped his hand. He asked the boy what he heard. He held the light. He let the boy find it. Later he said, I have been the arms my whole life. I didn't know a son was allowed to be carried. And my boy needed to see me allow it more than he needed a running truck. That's the hard part in this room. A lot of you have fathered yourselves since you were young. You can nod at every verse I just read and still lock up when it's time to be a son. Help feels like stepping off a ladder you've been standing on for years. The ground has been there. Your feet don't believe it yet.

So, uh, practice the receiving. Say Father where your own ears take it in. Keep God and Lord for your other prayers if you want. Give this one the name. Romans eight, verse fifteen. The Spirit you received brought about your adoption to sonship. And by him we cry, Abba, Father. Abba is, you know, a little kid's word. You're allowed to sound like that. It'll— it'll feel clumsy. Say it while it still does. First time I said it in the truck, I checked both mirrors, like somebody might report me. I said it again, uh, the next morning. Awkward counted. How many of you have never said it

out loud, where you could hear yourself? Go on. Alright. Capable men. The word can feel late. A son can start today. Bring Him, uh, the thing still messy. Before you polish it for a brother. Father, I am about to go cold on the people in my house. Father, I am headed back toward the thing I already told a man I quit. He can hear it uncleaned. Telling Him is not a pass to keep the exit. You already named the way you leave. He can hear it and still tell you to put it down. Then let Him, uh, tell you who you are. Read a sentence He has said about His sons. Answer it as true of you, because if you are in Christ, it is. A man who never heard his name needs it more than once. The Father has the patience for that. Let Him carry you, uh, in a way you can feel. Sometime soon, uh, something will be too heavy, and your reflex will be to grind it alone. Say the other sentence. This is past me. Father, hold it. Then let a brother in. Ask him to pray for you out loud, right there, and let him finish. Being prayed over is practice at being carried. Your pride will, you know, call it small. It is the ladder step. Stay where His voice actually is. His Word, on a plain day. His people, when you'd rather slip out. Prayer, when you have nothing impressive to report. A man who only shows up when something is on fire never learns the voice on an ordinary Tuesday.

Let me walk the room, slow. Uh, if you're young, learn this while you still think you don't need another father. You will save yourself years of looking for a man who can finish the sentence. If you're single, don't put the Father on layaway. Uh, I watched a younger man try to wait it out. I'll call him Ben. Single. Early in his working life. He told me he'd get serious about God as Father once he had a wife and a couple of kids, because that's when a man needs the pattern. I told him the order runs the other way. You are a son before you are anybody's husband. A wife will not be the voice from heaven. If you hand her that job, you will wear her out and stay a boy with a plan. Ben didn't need more life first. He needed the word while the apartment was still quiet. If you're married, I mean, your wife can be a gift and still not be your Father. You've heard me on this. I have handed her a job that was never hers. I still catch myself doing it. Take it— take it back. Let her be a wife. If the word was used to harm you, hear this kindly. God is not that man. You don't have to shrink the harm before you're allowed to say Father. Uh, if you're older, you are not late to be a son. The word may feel foolish the first mornings. Say it anyway. Foolish and true can share a mouth. And if the job is going well, don't bring a good report to a hunger it cannot feed. I had a stretch like that, you know. Somebody told me the work was strong. I said thanks. I sat in the truck after, and I was still hungry. A nod at work is not, with him I am well pleased. Once this Father is, uh, fathering you, your own dad gets smaller in the right way. You can honor what was good in him. You can name what harmed you and put the rage down. Forgiveness gets room when you quit waiting on him to pay a debt only God can pay. Some of you can still move toward him. Love can make that call. The call still cannot make him God.

Let me land it. Here is the whole thing. You learned the word father from a man. Jesus shows you the Father that word was always about. He comes toward you. He names you before you perform. He stays. He does not leave. What I hope you walk out with is not a fixed childhood

before supper. I hope you walk out knowing which picture you have been holding up to heaven, and one true thing Jesus shows about the Father who is actually there. Then I hope you say the word before you feel ready. The marks, once more, so they're in the room when you stand up. You've carried them through this room. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Today those marks sit in front of a Father who does not leave. That is the difference. Uh, get with the men at your table. Pull in. Open your workbook to this part. Work it, uh, out loud together. Three questions. Which picture have you been holding up to heaven? What one thing does Jesus show the Father is actually like? Can you say Father out loud seven mornings, before your feet hit the floor, one sentence to Him about the day, without waiting to feel it first? Then tell a brother which false father you have been praying to. Ask him to pray for you out loud, right there, and let him. If he rushes you, ask him to sit still. The Father stays. A brother can stay with you too. First John three, verse one. See what great love the Father has lavished on us, that we should be called children of God! And that is what we are! Say Father badly if you have to. Say it again. He has stayed through worse than an awkward morning. You are a son. The Father who said so does not leave.